

72 Absalom

David's handsome, charming son, who stole the people's hearts and rose up against his father.

Absalom was David's third son, famous for his good looks and thick hair. When his half-brother Amnon wronged his sister Tamar and David took no action, Absalom waited two years and had Amnon killed, then fled into exile. Back home, he won Israel's heart at the city gate, then had himself proclaimed king in Hebron and drove David out of Jerusalem. His rebellion ended in a forest battle, where he was caught in an oak and killed. David's cry of grief for him is one of the saddest lines in the Bible.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Avshalom</i> , "father of peace" or "my father is peace"
Family	David's third son; mother Maacah of Geshur (2 Samuel 3:3)
Children	Three sons and a daughter, Tamar (2 Samuel 14:27)
When	Born in Hebron, c. 1010–1003 BC; died in David's later reign
Key places	Hebron, Jerusalem, Geshur, the wood of Ephraim
Key people	David, Tamar, Amnon, Joab, Ahithophel, Hushai
New Testament	Not named

"And on this manner did Absalom to all Israel that came to the king for judgment: so Absalom stole the hearts of the men of Israel."

2 Samuel 15:6, KJV

The life of Absalom

Dates are approximate and rough (BC). Absalom was born during David's years in Hebron (c. 1010–1003 BC). The Bible counts the later years of his story in relation to each other, not in calendar dates.

c. 1010–1003 BC	● Born in Hebron While David reigns over Judah in Hebron, Absalom is born as his third son. His mother is Maacah, daughter of Talmai, king of Geshur, so Absalom has royal blood on both sides. <i>2 Samuel 3:2–5</i>
In Jerusalem	● Tamar is wronged Amnon, David's eldest son, forces himself on Absalom's sister Tamar and then throws her out. David is very angry, but the text records no action. Absalom takes Tamar into his house and says nothing to Amnon. <i>2 Samuel 13:1–22</i>
Two years later	● Amnon is killed Absalom invites the king's sons to his sheep-shearing at Baal-hazor. At his command his servants kill Amnon. Absalom flees to his grandfather in Geshur and stays three years. <i>2 Samuel 13:23–39</i>
After three years	● Returns home Joab arranges his return, but for two years Absalom does not see the king. After he burns Joab's field to get attention, David receives him and kisses him. <i>2 Samuel 14:1–33</i>
Later	● Steals Israel's heart He gathers chariots and runners and sits at the gate, winning over all who come for justice. Then he has himself proclaimed king in Hebron, and David flees Jerusalem. <i>2 Samuel 15:1–16:22</i>
The final battle	● Caught in an oak David's men defeat Absalom's army in the wood of Ephraim. Riding his mule under an oak, Absalom is caught by the head and left hanging. Joab kills him. <i>2 Samuel 18:1–17</i>

Key activities

2 Samuel 15:7 in the KJV says "after forty years." Some Greek and Syriac copies and the historian Josephus read "four years," which fits the story better, and many translations follow them. 2 Samuel 18:18 says Absalom had no son to carry his name, though 14:27 says he had three sons. They may have died young.

-
- 1 **Protected his sister.** After Tamar was wronged, he took her into his home, where she lived "desolate." 2 Samuel 13:20
 - 2 **Nursed his hatred.** He hated Amnon and waited two full years for revenge. 2 Samuel 13:22-29
 - 3 **Won the crowd.** He told each person with a complaint, "See, thy matters are good and right," and wished aloud that he were judge. 2 Samuel 15:1-6
 - 4 **Used a vow as cover.** He asked leave to go to Hebron to pay a vow, then sent spies through Israel to proclaim him king. 2 Samuel 15:7-12
 - 5 **Took bad advice over good.** He preferred Hushai's plan to Ahithophel's, because "the LORD had appointed to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel." 2 Samuel 17:1-14
 - 6 **Built his own monument.** Having no son to keep his name alive, he set up a pillar in the king's dale and called it "Absalom's place." 2 Samuel 18:18
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Absalom.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 3:3; 1 Chronicles 3:2	David's third son, born in Hebron
2 Samuel 13–19	The main account, through David's return
2 Samuel 18:33	"O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom!"
1 Kings 2:7, 28	Barzillai's kindness; Joab "turned not after Absalom"
Psalms 3	Title: "when he fled from Absalom his son"
Echo: 2 Samuel 12:10	The sword would never depart from David's house

New Testament

Echo: Luke 15:20	The prodigal's father runs to meet his son
Tradition	"Absalom's Tomb" in the Kidron Valley was built centuries later

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Absalom win the hearts of the people (2 Samuel 15:1–6)?
2. *Understand:* David was angry about Tamar but took no action. How might his silence have fed Absalom's bitterness?
3. *Apply:* Absalom nursed a grudge for years. Is there a wrong you keep replaying that you need to bring to God?
4. *Apply:* David grieved his son even after the rebellion. Who in your family needs your love even when relationships are hard?